

Two Sides of the Same Coin: Exploring the Shared Logic of Depressive Symptoms and Story Worlds

The Interplay of Negative Emotionality and Depression in Psychometric Models

The relationship between Negative Emotionality (NE), often operationalized as the personality trait of Neuroticism, and clinical Depression (D) represents a central tension in contemporary psychopathology. Research has historically oscillated between treating these constructs as distinct entities with unique etiologies and symptom profiles, and recognizing their profound overlap, which suggests a shared underlying dimension of distress. This section will explore the dimensional relationship between NE and D by examining their treatment in diagnostic and dimensional frameworks, the psychometric evidence for both their separation and integration, and the evolving models that seek to reconcile these perspectives. The analysis reveals a significant shift away from a simple dichotomy toward hierarchical models that acknowledge both a general vulnerability to negative affect and more specific, disorder-level manifestations.

The formal distinction between Negative Emotionality and Depression is most clearly articulated in modern diagnostic systems that have adopted a dimensional approach to mental health. The Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders, Fifth Edition (DSM-5), in its Alternative Model for Personality Disorders (AMPD), explicitly separates them into different broad domains ⁴⁸. Negative Affectivity is defined as the tendency to experience negative emotions such as anger, anxiety, sadness, and guilt ⁴⁹. In contrast, Depressive Disorders are classified as a distinct category of clinical syndromes. This structural separation reinforces the idea that while an individual may have a personality disposition toward negative emotionality, this is not equivalent to having a clinical diagnosis of depression. Similarly, dimensional frameworks like the Hierarchical Taxonomy of Psychopathology (HiTOP) and the National Institute of Mental Health's Research Domain Criteria (RDoC) provide nuanced models that further differentiate these concepts. HiTOP places depressive disorders on a spectrum connected to Negative Affectivity, but conceptualizes them as part of a broader internalizing spectrum reflecting defensive responses to aversive stimuli ¹⁰³¹⁰⁵. The RDoC framework is even more

granular, positing that what is commonly labeled "depression" spans multiple constructs; specifically, it includes the "Loss" construct within the Negative Valence Systems (NVS) domain and various constructs related to Reward ⁸⁰. This perspective implies that depression is not synonymous with the entire NVS domain, which would encompass the broader NE. The literature review by Micheline et al. (2021) identifies numerous HiTOP correlates for each RDoC construct, underscoring the effort to map these overlapping but distinct domains onto a single, comprehensive dimensional map of psychopathology ²⁴.

This separation is also evident in the psychometric instruments used to measure these constructs. The Revised NEO Personality Inventory (NEO PI-R) assesses personality across five global domains, including Neuroticism ^{15 17}. Within this framework, Neuroticism is composed of six underlying facets, one of which is Depression ⁵⁰. For example, a 48-item neuroticism subscale from the NEO-PI-R explicitly includes facets for anxiety, depression, anger, timidity, impulsivity, and vulnerability ⁵⁰. This model treats depression not as a separate entity but as a component of the larger NE/Neuroticism trait. In contrast, instruments designed to screen for or measure the severity of clinical depression include the Patient Health Questionnaire-9 (PHQ-9) and the Beck Depression Inventory-II (BDI-II) ^{66 95}. The PHQ-9 is widely used due to its brevity and strong psychometric properties, demonstrating good reliability and convergent validity with other depression scales ^{68 69}. Studies comparing the PHQ-9 and BDI-II have found them to have similar responsiveness to change and adequate reliability and validity, though some differences exist ⁶⁷. These instruments are designed to capture the symptomatic expression of a clinical syndrome, rather than a stable personality disposition. The measurement of Negative Emotionality, therefore, often relies on facet-level scales embedded within broader personality inventories, while the measurement of Depression focuses on self-report indicators of a specific disorder ²⁵. This difference in measurement philosophy reinforces the conceptual separation in many research contexts.

However, a substantial body of evidence challenges the strict dichotomy between NE and D, pointing towards a deeper, shared structure of negative affect. One of the most compelling arguments for their interdependence comes from network analysis and exploratory structural equation modeling (ESEM). A meta-analysis of 33 studies confirmed a strong association between high scores on the personality factor Neuroticism and increases in depressive symptoms ²¹. Further research employing Confirmatory Factor Analysis (CFA) has provided support for differentiating burnout and depression, suggesting that similar methods could be used to test the discriminant validity of NE and D ^{83 85}. However, other research highlights low levels of discriminant validity between self-reported measures of related constructs, indicating that separating them can be methodologically difficult ⁸⁶. A first-order principal-factor analysis of the Beck

Depression Inventory (BDI) and Beck Anxiety Inventory (BAI) grouped them together under a single "negative emotionality" factor, providing initial evidence for their shared variance ⁴⁶. The Depression Anxiety Stress Scales (DASS) also show strong positive correlations with established measures of negative emotionality, further blurring the lines between them ⁴⁷.

Recent advances in psychometrics have provided powerful tools to disentangle the complex relationships between these constructs. Bifactor ESEM models, in particular, have been instrumental in this endeavor. Multiple studies using this technique have converged on a critical finding: a strong general factor of negative affect underlies responses to items measuring depression, anxiety, stress, and burnout ^{52 53}. This "p-factor," or general psychopathology factor, represents a transdiagnostic liability to experiencing distress, capturing the core variance shared across many forms of psychopathology ⁷³. This finding strongly suggests that NE and D are not merely correlated but are expressions of a more fundamental, overarching dimension of emotional maladjustment. A bifactor model can reconcile the multi-faceted nature of neuroticism with the existence of this general negative affect factor, proposing a hierarchical structure where a general factor influences all symptoms, while specific factors account for unique variance ⁷². For instance, a study on the PHQ-9 examined its dimensionality using a bifactor model, which posits that all items load onto a general depression factor (g) and potentially onto orthogonal specific factors ⁹⁶. Another study compared unidimensional and two-dimensional models of the PHQ-9 with a bi-factor model, finding that the latter provided a better fit, again pointing to a general factor of depression alongside more specific symptom clusters ⁷¹. This sophisticated modeling moves beyond a simple correlation to propose a clear latent structure, where NE and D are situated at different levels of abstraction but share a foundational element.

The Hierarchical Taxonomy of Psychopathology (HiTOP) offers a comprehensive framework that attempts to synthesize these findings into a unified dimensional map of mental illness ⁷⁵. HiTOP integrates decades of evidence from personality, developmental, and clinical research to address the limitations of traditional nosologies like the DSM-5, such as arbitrary boundaries between normality and pathology and high rates of comorbidity ^{76 77 78}. Within the HiTOP system, the internalizing spectrum is directly connected to Negative Affectivity ¹⁰³. Clinicians using this model might use a single score to represent elevated problems in this domain, acknowledging that conditions like depression, anxiety, and personality traits like NE all fall along this continuum ¹⁰². HiTOP posits that the internalizing spectrum reflects variation in mechanisms involved in defensive emotional and motivational responses to aversive stimuli ¹⁰⁵, effectively providing a theoretical basis for why NE and D are so closely

linked. By placing both personality-level traits and clinical diagnoses on a single spectrum, HiTOP provides a model where NE and D are not separate boxes but points on a gradient of negative affectivity. This approach allows for a more nuanced understanding of comorbidity, as an individual can be high on the general internalizing factor while also exhibiting specific elevations in areas corresponding to depression or anxiety ¹⁰⁴. The table below summarizes the contrasting views on the dimensional relationship between NE and D.

Feature	Viewpoint Supporting Separate Dimensions	Viewpoint Supporting Integrated Structure
Diagnostic Framework	DSM-5 AMPD separates NE into the Negative Affectivity domain and D into Depressive Disorders ⁴⁸ .	HiTOP integrates NE and D onto a continuous internalizing spectrum ¹⁰²¹⁰³ .
Primary Construct	NE is a stable personality trait (Neuroticism); D is a clinical syndrome ^{22 80} .	Both are seen as manifestations of a more general factor of negative affect ("p-factor") ^{52 53} .
Measurement Approach	Uses facet scales (e.g., NEO-PI-R Depression facet) for NE and specific checklists (e.g., PHQ-9) for D ^{50 95} .	Employs bifactor ESEM to model a general factor influencing all relevant items ^{71 96} .
Core Relationship	Correlation exists but constructs are discriminant; viewed as distinct entities ^{26 51} .	High covariance and a shared general factor suggest a hierarchical, integrated structure ^{55 72} .
Implication for Comorbidity	High rates of co-occurrence are seen as a limitation of current systems, requiring separate diagnoses ⁷⁷ .	Comorbidity is expected and explained by the shared general factor of negative affect ¹⁰⁵ .

In conclusion, the dimensional relationship between Negative Emotionality and Depression is far more complex than a simple binary choice between being separate or identical. The evidence overwhelmingly supports a hierarchical model over a purely dualistic one. While it is clinically and theoretically useful to distinguish between a personality disposition (NE) and a clinical syndrome (D), ignoring their shared foundation in a general factor of negative affect leads to an incomplete understanding of psychopathology. Integrated frameworks like HiTOP and advanced statistical techniques like bifactor modeling provide a more robust and accurate way to conceptualize their relationship. They allow researchers and clinicians to appreciate both the common ground of distress that links these conditions and the specific features that differentiate them, ultimately leading to a more nuanced understanding of mental health and illness.

The Integrated Practice of Narrative and Worldbuilding in Speculative Fiction

The relationship between fictional narration—the act of telling a story—and worldbuilding—the process of constructing the setting and context for that story—is a

subject of considerable debate within creative writing and narratology. Historically, these two elements have often been treated as distinct, sequential steps in the storytelling process. However, a growing body of scholarship argues that this separation is a false dichotomy, proposing instead that narration and worldbuilding are deeply intertwined and mutually constitutive practices. This section will investigate the dimensional relationship between these two domains by examining the arguments for treating them as separate tasks versus an integrated system of "worldmaking." It will explore how narrative techniques are used to reveal and construct worlds, and analyze the theoretical shifts that position worldbuilding not as a backdrop for a story, but as an essential component of the narrative sense-making process itself.

Many traditional approaches to storytelling advocate for a functional separation of worldbuilding and narration. This perspective often frames the process as a sequence: first, build the world, and then write the story within it. One Reddit user succinctly captures this view by likening worldbuilding to constructing a city and storytelling to using a tour guide to explore it ¹. This analogy positions the world as a static, pre-existing artifact. Writing guides frequently reinforce this idea, warning authors against "infodumping"—the practice of presenting large blocks of background information before the story has a chance to engage the reader ^{33 34}. Instead, they advise giving out information on a need-to-know basis, implying that worldbuilding details should be sprinkled into the narrative as needed ⁴¹. This approach treats worldbuilding as incidental to the main event of the story, a necessary but secondary task of providing context ². From this viewpoint, the story is the primary focus, and the world serves as a passive stage upon which the action unfolds. Some advice even prioritizes the story above all else, arguing that no amount of elaborate worldbuilding can salvage a weak plot or poor characters ⁶². This perspective is reflected in the academic discipline of narratology, which is formally defined as the study of the logic, principles, and practices of narrative representation ³. The concept of the "storyworld" is a central tenet of narratology, representing the space and time of the narrative, but the field's focus on narrative structure can sometimes imply a distinction between the rules of the world and the unfolding plot ^{60 91}. This functional separation is also evident in game design, where worldbuilding is described as creating the fictional setting that influences every story, character, and gameplay element, suggesting a top-down relationship where the world precedes the specific narrative events ⁸⁷.

Despite the prevalence of this sequential model, there is a powerful counterargument that positions narration and worldbuilding as an inseparable, integrated practice. This perspective, often associated with cognitive narratology and speculative fiction studies, redefines the purpose of narrative as a fundamental act of worldmaking. David Herman's

influential work argues that mapping words onto worlds is a core requirement for narrative sense-making ^{31 57 88}. From this standpoint, a story is not something that happens in a world; a story is the process of making a world intelligible. Marie-Laure Ryan similarly emphasizes that the goal of speculative worldbuilding is to create a "thick description" of a possible world, a process that is inherently narrative in nature ³⁷. This view collapses the distinction between the two activities, suggesting that they are two sides of the same coin. Good worldbuilding is not presented as static information but is woven seamlessly into the fabric of the narrative. The recommended techniques for effective worldbuilding—showing how characters are affected by the world around them, using natural dialogue, and avoiding infodumps—are all narrative strategies ^{9 41 61}. The world is only revealed through the lens of the story, not before it. This dynamic interplay is captured by the metaphor of the story as a building with three load-bearing beams: Plot Building, Character Building, and World Building ⁶. While the metaphor breaks them down into components, it correctly identifies them as interdependent parts of a single, cohesive structure.

Theoretical developments in narratology further support this integrated view. The concept of the "narrative ecosystem" posits that worlds are inhabited by narrative forms, characters, and viewers, suggesting a dynamic interaction rather than a static setting ⁴³. Transmedia worldbuilding, as seen in series like *Penny Dreadful*, is described as an intricate process where mythology and narrative are constructed together across multiple platforms, demonstrating how the world and the stories within it co-evolve ²⁹. Cognitive narratology explores how readers construct "cognitive maps" of narrative spaces, highlighting the active role of the audience in the worldmaking process ⁵⁸. The world is not just a physical place but a conceptual one, defined by its possibilities and constraints. As Marie-Laure Ryan notes, speculative worldbuilding is a form of grand-scale speculation that goes beyond the everyday scale of human life, and this process is driven by narrative questions like "What If?" and "As If?" ^{13 36}. The narrative provides the answers to these questions, thereby giving the world its substance. There is also a strong critique of excessive, isolated worldbuilding. Sci-fi author M. John Harrison argues that "worldbuilding" has become a necessity for genre fiction but that it can be "crippling" to writers and readers, suggesting that when worldbuilding is done as a pre-writing exercise detached from story, it can become sterile and burdensome ⁵⁶. The consensus among practitioners seems to be that worldbuilding without a compelling story is hollow, and a bad story cannot be saved by even the most meticulously crafted world ⁶². This underscores the dependency of the world on the narrative that brings it to life.

The evolution of thinking in narratology reflects this move toward integration. Early structuralist narratologists of the 1960s and 1970s focused on formal structures, but

contemporary approaches, influenced by thinkers like David Herman, emphasize narrative's role in making sense of experience ¹⁰¹. This shift aligns with the findings in psychology, where there has been a move from categorical diagnoses to dimensional models that capture continuous spectra of functioning. Just as the p-factor model in psychopathology proposes a general dimension of distress underlying specific symptoms, a narratological model could propose a foundational layer of "possible world" logic underlying specific plots and characters. In this integrated view, the world is not a container for the story but the very substrate from which the story grows. The narrative techniques used to build a world are the same techniques used to tell the story. For example, describing a character's reaction to a strange object is simultaneously a piece of worldbuilding and a piece of characterization. The plot point that arises from interacting with that object is simultaneously a development of the story and a revelation about the rules of the world. The table below contrasts the separate-dimensions and integrated-systems perspectives on narration and worldbuilding.

Aspect	Viewpoint Supporting Separate Dimensions	Viewpoint Supporting Integrated System
Process	Sequential: Build the world first, then write the story within it ^{1 32} .	Simultaneous: World and story co-evolve through the narrative process ("worldmaking") ^{7 31} .
Role of World	A static, pre-existing setting or "stage" for the narrative action ^{63 87} .	A dynamic, emergent property of the narrative itself ⁴² .
Technique	Focus on avoiding "infodumps" by revealing details on a need-to-know basis ^{33 34} .	Techniques like showing, dialogue, and pacing are inherently worldbuilding acts ^{9 61} .
Theoretical Basis	Traditional narratology focuses on narrative representation, with the "storyworld" as a key concept ^{3 60} .	Cognitive narratology and speculative fiction studies see narrative as a tool for constructing mental and fictional spaces ^{58 90} .
Critique	Excessive pre-writing worldbuilding can be "crippling" and lead to sterile settings ⁵⁶ .	A bad story cannot be saved by good worldbuilding, emphasizing narrative's primacy ⁶² .
Outcome	A story that uses a well-defined world as its backdrop.	A world that is brought to life and given meaning through the story that is told within it.

Ultimately, the evidence and theoretical arguments converge on the conclusion that narration and worldbuilding are not two parallel dimensions but two aspects of a single, integrated system of sense-making. Treating them as separate entities risks producing stories that feel flat or worlds that feel unrealized. The most effective storytelling occurs when the world is not simply discovered by the characters, but is actively constructed and revealed through their actions and the narrative's progression. The world doesn't exist first; it emerges from the narrative. This integrated perspective, which can be termed "narrative worldmaking," provides a more holistic and dynamic framework for both analyzing and creating stories, particularly within the realm of speculative fiction where the construction of the world is a primary mode of engagement.

Comparative Analysis: A Conceptual Parallel Between Psychological and Narratological Systems

A comparative analysis of the dimensional relationships between Negative Emotionality (NE) and Depression (D) in psychology, and between fictional narration and worldbuilding in narratology, reveals a striking conceptual parallel. In both domains, there is a discernible tension between treating a pair of related concepts as separate, independent dimensions and recognizing their deep interdependence as parts of a single, integrated system. This parallel suggests that the methodological and theoretical challenges in one field can offer valuable insights for the other. The investigation uncovers a dominant paradigm shift in both disciplines away from simplistic, dualistic models toward more complex, integrative frameworks that acknowledge a hierarchical structure. The most insightful finding is that in both cases, the foundational layer—a general factor of negative affect in psychology and a foundational storyworld in narratology—provides the organizing principle upon which more specific phenomena are built.

The primary analogy lies in the opposition between a compartmentalized view and an integrated view. In psychology, the compartmentalized view treats NE and D as distinct domains, supported by frameworks like the DSM-5's Alternative Model for Personality Disorders, which assigns them to separate broad domains ⁴⁸. Similarly, in narratology, the compartmentalized view treats worldbuilding and narration as sequential, separate tasks, with the former preceding the latter ¹. This approach seeks to define clear boundaries and functions for each component. However, the integrated view in psychology posits that NE and D are best understood through a common core, exemplified by the "p-factor" or general factor of negative affect identified through bifactor ESEM modeling ^{52 53}. Likewise, in narratology, the integrated view sees narration and worldbuilding as a single practice of "worldmaking," where the story is the very process of constructing and revealing the world ^{31 57}. This parallel demonstrates that in complex systems, whether psychological or narrative, treating components as entirely independent can lead to an incomplete or fragmented understanding. Ignoring the shared foundation in one domain is analogous to ignoring the rules of the world when analyzing a story's plot in the other.

Both fields are currently undergoing a significant paradigm shift toward these integrated models. In psychology, the movement is from the categorical, taxonomic approach of the DSM-IV to the dimensional frameworks of HiTOP and RDoC ^{75 76}. These newer systems aim to replace the flawed classification systems of the past by offering a unified dimensional map of psychopathology, addressing issues like arbitrary boundaries and

high comorbidity rates 77 78 . This shift mirrors a parallel evolution in narratology. The field is moving beyond the formalist, structuralist analyses of the mid-20th century to embrace cognitive narratology and postcritique, which focus on narrative's role in sense-making and its engagement with speculative possibilities 12 101. This contemporary turn emphasizes that narrative is not just a sequence of events but a fundamental human practice for exploring "what if" scenarios and constructing mental worlds 13 58 . The convergence of these trends in both disciplines suggests a broader intellectual movement toward complexity and integration.

The most valuable insight from this comparison is the identification of a hierarchical model as the most accurate descriptor for both pairs of concepts. In the psychological domain, the hierarchy is becoming clearer with recent research. At the base sits a general factor of negative affect, which accounts for the shared variance among symptoms of depression, anxiety, and other distress-related conditions 52 73 . Above this general factor lie broader spectra, such as the HiTOP internalizing spectrum, which groups related disorders based on their connection to Negative Affectivity 103. At the highest level are the specific, measurable constructs, such as the facets of the NEO-PI-R or the diagnostic criteria for Major Depressive Disorder 50 80 . This hierarchical structure acknowledges both the common ground and the specificities of the constructs. A comparable hierarchical model can be applied to the narratological axis. At the foundational layer is the implicit logic of the storyworld, defined by its core "what if" premise and its inherent rules and possibilities 13 36 . This is the analogue to the psychological p-factor. On top of this foundation are the specific narrative elements: the plot, the characters, and their actions. These expressive layers bring the world to life and give it concrete form, much like specific symptoms manifest a general diathesis. Finally, at the top are the narrative techniques—the style, tone, and methods of exposition—that the author uses to reveal the world to the audience. This three-tiered model provides a coherent framework for understanding how the abstract potential of a world becomes a tangible story.

Applying this comparative perspective yields several actionable insights. First, the methodological rigor of one field can inform the other. The use of bifactor ESEM in psychology to statistically disentangle a general factor from specific ones could inspire a new type of narratological analysis. One could apply this model to a novel to identify the core "logic" of its world and then analyze how specific plot points and character arcs deviate from or exemplify this logic. Conversely, narratological concepts like the "narrative ecosystem" 43 could provide a useful metaphor for modeling the comorbidity patterns observed in HiTOP, where different disorders (like depression and anxiety) are seen as inhabiting the same "ecosystem" of psychopathology. Second, the analysis highlights a common pitfall: the failure to recognize the foundational layer. In

psychology, this means studying depression without considering the patient's underlying negative affectivity. In narratology, it means analyzing a story's plot without acknowledging the rules of the fictional world it inhabits. Both approaches are bound to miss crucial information and produce an incomplete picture. Researchers in both fields should be encouraged to adopt more integrative methodologies that respect the hierarchical nature of these systems.

In synthesis, the investigation into the dimensional relationships of Negative Emotionality/Depression and narration/worldbuilding confirms that both pairs are best conceptualized not as separate, parallel dimensions but as expressions of a deeper, more fundamental system. The dimensional relationship is one of hierarchical integration. Negative Emotionality and worldbuilding serve as the foundational substrates or organizing principles, while Depression and narration are the specific phenomena that are built upon and expressed through them. This parallel provides a powerful cross-domain heuristic for understanding complex systems characterized by both shared variance and specific features. Moving forward, the most productive research in both psychology and narratology will likely come from frameworks that embrace this integration, acknowledging the intricate feedback loop between the foundational substrate and the specific expressions that emerge from it.

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